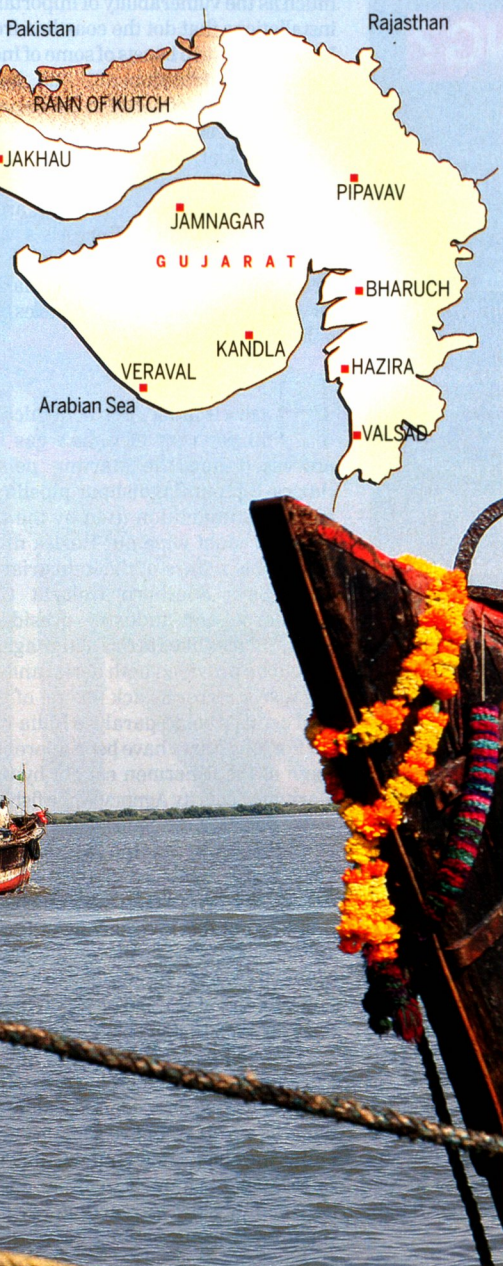


Sitting DUCKS

In the absence of a coastal security plan, some of India's biggest industries located from Kutch to Valsad are most vulnerable to terrorist attacks



SHAILESH RAVAL

its warships attacked Karachi, the Indian Navy will not be celebrating Navy Day as the nation mourns the mayhem caused by the first maritime terror attack against the country. But, it isn't the first time terrorists struck from the sea. In 1993, boats brought in RDX from Pakistan which were used to blast 13 targets killing 257 people in Mumbai. Under its Coastal Security Scheme in January 2005, the Union Government even sanctioned Rs 742 crore for setting up specialised marine police stations with speedboats and dedicated personnel in the eight states and four Union territories which make up the 7,600-km Indian coastline.

Three of the states—Tamil Nadu, Orissa and Kerala—are yet to implement the scheme while Maharashtra has only just begun. This when sealing of borders has made it easier for terrorists to slip in through the sea. Intelligence Bureau alerts in the past two years warned of the likelihood of Pakistan Navy and ISI-trained terrorists planning to infiltrate the coast disguised as fishermen. "We have been asking the Government for two years to install some sort of vessel traffic management system (or VTMS which can identify location of all trawlers using beacons) and electronic cards for fishermen," says a senior navy official.

The Coast Guard's western region, which polices the 3,300-km sensitive coastline between Gujarat and Kerala has a fleet of just 14 ships of various sizes and eight surveillance aircraft whereas it actually needs a fleet of at least 50 ships and 36 aircraft. Neither the Coast Guard nor the navy has the authority to stop and search merchant vessels—that is the sole prerogative of the Director-General of Shipping, a shore-based bureaucrat with no personnel or ships.

After the 9/11 attacks, the United States consolidated 22 agencies including the Customs and Coast Guard under the umbrella of the Department of Homeland Security (DHS). In India defence of the coast is left to the navy and Coast Guard operating under the Ministry of Defence, formulating maritime policy is lost in a bureaucratic labyrinth. In addition to the eight coastal states and four Union territories, there are currently 12 ministries and eight departments of the Central Government involved in maritime-related policy formulation and implementation. This results in overlapping

**INTELLIGENCE REPORTS
HAVE WARNED OF THE
LIKELIHOOD OF TERROR-
ISTS TRYING TO SNEAK IN
POSING AS FISHERMEN**